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Cold case unit launched for missing and murdered - Seattle Times, The (WA) - April 24, 2023 - page A 8
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A new Washington law will create a cold case unit focused on investigating unsolved cases of **missing** and **murdered Indigenous** people.

Signed into law by Gov. Jay Inslee on Thursday, House Bill 1177 aims to bring justice and closure to**Native American** and Alaska **Native** families, some of whom have been waiting decades for answers on what happened to their loved one.

"Victims are not alone. The cries of their loved ones are no longer unheard," said bill sponsor Rep. Debra Lekanoff, D-Bow, who was born in Southeast Alaska and is part Tlingit and part Aleut.

The cold case unit, which will be housed in the state Attorney General's Office, will assist federal, local and tribal law enforcement agencies in investigating unsolved cases involving **Indigenous** people, who are disproportionately targeted by **violence**. The unit will prioritize help to jurisdictions with limited resources.

In addition to investigators, the unit will include an advocate who will maintain regular and confidential communication with families of victims, using culturally appropriate and trauma-informed practices, and serve as a go-between for families and law enforcement.

Proponents of the new cold case unit say it is a step toward thawing historical mistrust and fear in **Indigenous** communities toward the police and court systems.

The new cold case unit was a major recommendation brought forward last summer by the Washington State **Missing** and **Murdered Indigenous Women** & People Task Force, which was created by the office in 2021.

"Thanks to the work of the task force, my office will be the first Attorney General's Office in the country with a cold case unit dedicated to seeking justice for **missing** and **murdered Indigenous women** and people," Attorney General Bob Ferguson said in a statement.

The task force also pushed for the creation of a new emergency alert system for **missing Indigenous** people, similar to Amber Alerts for children and Silver Alerts for older adults.

Since launching in July, the new alert system has been activated 54 times, with 43 people ultimately found alive. In at least 11 cases, the alert helped law enforcement agencies find the **missing** person, according to the Washington State Patrol.

For decades, **Native American** advocates and experts have sounded the alarm on the disproportionate levels of **violence**, sexual assault, homicides and disappearances experienced by **Indigenous** people, and particularly by **women**.

"I can't say why it took so long for the rest of the country or our state to recognize we matter," Lekanoff said. Across the country, "there are thousands of **women** we still don't know what happened to them, they're still **missing**."

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reported that in 2018, homicide was the sixth leading cause of death for **Indigenous women** and **girls** ages 1 to 44. For **Indigenous** men and boys, it was the third leading cause of death.

Washington has one of the highest number of cases of **missing** or **murdered Native American women** and **girls** in the country, according to a 2018 report by the Urban **Indian** Health Institute. Researchers at the time identified 45 cases in Seattle, the highest number among the cities it reviewed, though advocates and experts say it's likely an undercount.

A review by the Attorney General's Office in 2022 found at least 113 unsolved homicide cases involving an

Indigenous victim, or about 5% of recorded unsolved homicides. **Indigenous** people represent about 2% of the state's population.

The office noted the disparity is likely "much more significant," since many cases involving **Indigenous** victims may be inaccurately reported, or not reported at all.

As of April, 134 **Native American** people are **missing** in Washington, the majority from Yakima County, according to the State Patrol.

"It's a crisis, and we're finally able to take small, positive steps here in Washington state," Lekanoff said.

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